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The Body Is in the Tomb

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The Body Is in the Tomb

Today's Reading: John 19:38-42

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"Now in the place where he was crucified there was a garden, and in the garden a new tomb in which no one had been laid. So because of the Jewish day of Preparation, since the tomb was close at hand, they laid Jesus there."

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When Jesus was taken down from the cross, Joseph of Arimathea, a wealthy member of the Sanhedrin, gave over use of his tomb in devotion to the Lord. It was new; no one had ever been laid in it. Nicodemus, another member of the Sanhedrin, provided burial spices with which to anoint Jesus' body.

The Lord's body then was wrapped in linen cloths and burial spices. These linen cloths are sometimes called swaddling cloths. Ironically, when Jesus departed the world, he was dressed the same way as when he entered it.

The Jewish day of preparation was at hand. Jesus was laid in the tomb right before the Sabbath was to begin and all work must cease— including carrying linen wrappings, spices, and a dead corpse. Everything had been completed quickly for his burial.

Then a large stone was rolled in front of the tomb. It was sealed to assure no one could enter. After all, on several occasions, Jesus had prophesied that he would be crucified and raised from the dead. If this seal was broken and the body stolen, the guards would have to pay the price of the condemned prisoner. In this case, the guards overseeing Jesus' body would face crucifixion themselves if his body was taken.

Everyone left the tomb except the Roman guards. They were highly motivated to make sure Jesus' body remained there. Pilate and the Jewish leaders did not want to take a chance on Jesus rising from the dead, or his disciples stealing the body. They wanted the certainty of his dead body in the tomb to squelch any rumors about a resurrection.

Is it important for people to know the actual location of Jesus' actual burial site? Most likely, no. Through the centuries, people have debated where his body was actually laid. In Jerusalem, there are three potential burial sites that historians point to and people visit.

No one knows with certainty the true burial site. That is probably God's preference. He wouldn't want people worshiping a shrine where they think Jesus was buried. People love to worship places and build monuments that end up becoming a substitute for an authentic faith.

God may have purposely hidden the burial place, just as he hid Moses's burial place. He understands human nature. He knows how people are prone to worship creation instead of the Creator. He wants them to worship him alone.

At the same time, consider this: All three potential burial sites have one thing in common: Each one is empty. Jesus is not in any of them.

And rest assured of this: If any of Jesus' enemies could have produced a body to show that he had never risen, they would have. Show his corpse, and his movement is finished. But no one could. He has risen from the dead. He is alive!

The grave could not hold him. Death could not contain him. His victory over sin and death is complete.

And if you believe in him, your victory is certain as well.

[from *"Hearing the Voice of God"* by Pastor David Chadwick, Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC]